

No Exit in Hell: A Role-Switching Narrative Experience in VR Theatre

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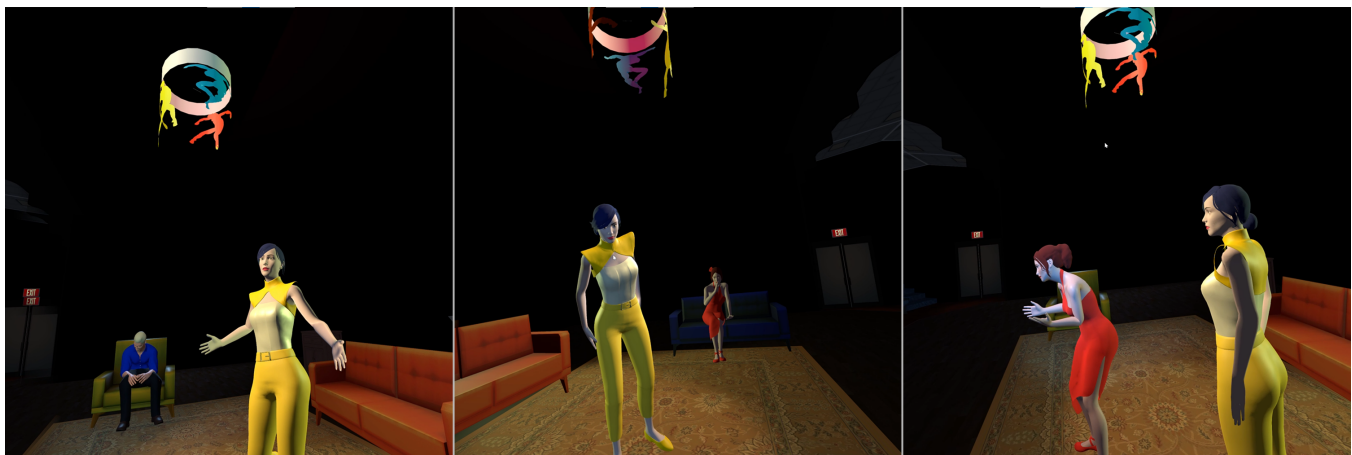


Figure 1: Screenshots of different perspectives(roles) that viewers take.

ABSTRACT

No Exit in Hell is an innovative recreation of Jean-Paul Sartre's classic play No Exit in VR theatre. It immerses viewers in a novel narrative experience by not only bringing realistic theatre acting into virtual reality but also allowing them to take on different roles of the play. In this role-switching experience, gamification designs are integrated to guide viewers through each role transformation and maintain their focus, ensuring that every shift in character unveils a new facet of the story.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → Virtual reality; • Applied computing → Performing arts.

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KEYWORDS

Virtual Reality Theatre, Role-switching, Narrative design

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1 INTRODUCTION

No Exit in Hell is dedicated to exploring the possibilities of immersive storytelling and interactive experiences, offering an innovative recreation of Jean-Paul Sartre's classic play No Exit in VR theatre. This work not only transposes the existential narrative into virtual reality but also introduces a unique role-switching mechanism, allowing viewers to experience the story from different perspectives.

2 DESIGN

2.1 Role-Switching

Role-Switching is a special narrative mechanism of switching the role of viewers during VR narrative experiences. In No Exit in Hell, the viewer's role shifts multiple times, enabling them to grasp the

essence of the play from different perspectives. Upon entering the VR theatre, the viewer starts as an anonymous audience. As the experience progresses, they step into the spotlight and successively switches to the roles of Estelle Rigault, Joseph Garcin, and In  z Serrano (figure 1). This approach deepens the narrative experience while sparking new insights of the play.

2.2 Script Adaptation

No Exit is a 1944 existentialist play by Jean-Paul Sartre that depicts three damned souls, Joseph Garcin, In  z Serrano, and Estelle Rigault, locked together in a room for eternity in Hell [Sartre 1944]. They gradually reveal their sins and realise they are each other's torturers, encapsulating Sartre's famous notion "Hell is other people." To accommodate the role-switching mechanism and align with the characteristics of VR theatre, careful adaptation of the original script was undertaken. The main plot was concisely abstracted in case the viewer gets impatient during long noninteractive moments. Nevertheless, essential fragments that reveal the paradox and depict the conflicts and sins of the character were reserved. Additionally, we wrote lines for each character in their respective tones to express their thoughts directly to the viewer.

2.3 Gamification Designs

Given the frequent role transformations required in the narrative experience, it is crucial to ensure that viewers can seamlessly immerse themselves in each new role and maintain focus until the next transformation. To achieve this, gamification elements such as Multiple Choice Dialogues and Quick-Time Events (QTE) are integrated into appropriate parts of the narrative experience.

3 IMPLEMENTATION

3.1 Motion Capture

To bring realistic acting into virtual reality, we used the Vicon optical motion capture system to capture the performances of our actors, all well-trained in realistic theatre acting. By retargeting the captured motion data into our 3D characters (figure 2), we believe we have achieved a decent reproduction of the original performances.

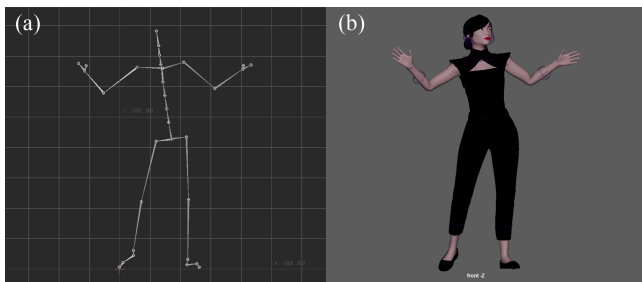


Figure 2: (a) Captured motion data, (b) 3D character with baked animation from the captured motion data.

3.2 Development in Unity

No Exit in Hell was developed in Unity3D using the SteamVR Plugin and was run and tested on HTC Vive Pro 2.

4 CONCLUSION

No Exit in Hell employs a unique role-switching narrative design to immerse viewers in Sartre's classic play in VR theatre. We invited diverse groups of viewers to experience this work. While most acknowledged that the role-switching mechanism offers multiple perspectives and a novel experience, some found it difficult to transition between roles, and some prefer a continuous experience in a single role. Moving forward, we are committed to refining our narrative and interaction design based on insights gained from in-depth viewer interviews, hoping to contribute to future developments in this exciting field.

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Jean-Paul Sartre. 1944. *No Exit*. Gallimard, Paris. Original French title: Huis Clos.